



(Don't Write anything in this Area)

- 7.c) The concept of cultural relativism and the ensuing debates surrounding it have sparked discussions within Anthropology. Comment. (15 marks)

Cultural relativism is a concept introduced in Anthropology by FRANZ BOAS.

Cultural relativism is a practice of studying the society based on its societal and cultural content.

Features of cultural relativism

- ① Not judging the society.
- ② No comparison made.
- ③ Includes subjectivity.
- ④ Cultural trait exists in the society depending on various factors like history, economy, political set up.
- ⑤ This school of thought was a reaction towards classical evolutionist and diffusionist.

Debates surrounding cultural relativism

The cultural relativism is criticized by ELIZABETH ZACHENTER.

- She says cultural relativism has led to paralysis of human rights
 (e.g.) Female genital Mutilation is a practice of the society & part of its culture.

However it is against basic human rights.

- She argues that cultural relativism is nothing but the imposition of the moral impotency.

Thus Anthropologist agrees that the current position is not ideal as there exist conflicts between cultural relativism (vs) Human rights.

But it is also agreed that, cultural relativism is the best that is available for present evaluation.

An anthropologist needs to pass the stage of cultural relativism to understand the society better.

(6)

Fundamental principles should be made universal - slavery, mutilation - criticised.
- sex, language, food & art - can vary
Freedom to be practiced → Relative.

Watch Discussion
12:44.